

INDIA'S DELAYED RESPONSE A model of the AMCA (Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft)—it will take a decade for India's fifth generation fighter jet to enter production and counter China's stealth fighters

as well. In contrast, already liberally supplied with J-20 and J-35 fifth generation stealth fighters by its burgeoning military-industrial complex, China has forged further ahead by unveiling designs for two sixth generation fighter jets on December 26—the larger J-36, a tailless stealth fighter undergoing tests, and the smaller J-50. It underscores China's relentless drive to dominate the skies and challenge American aerial dominance. Alarmingly, Pakistan, too, is rapidly bolstering its aerial capabilities. In a move that could dramatically alter South Asia's air dominance dynamics, Pakistan has fast-tracked the acquisition of 40 J-35 stealth fighters from China, with deliveries expected by 2026. Potentially, both these air forces can drive the IAF from the skies in the near future. Adding to New Delhi's concern is China's potential sale of advanced fighters to Bangladesh.

In comparison, India's efforts to secure air dominance hang in the balance. Over 100 aerospace engineers at the Aeronautical Development Agency (ADA) in Bengaluru are designing India's fifth-generation stealth fighter, the Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA), but progress has been painfully slow. Since the programme's inception in 2009, AMCA's development timeline has stretched on and on. Its earliest prototype is expected by 2028, with mass production not anticipated until 2035. Fifth generation fighters have stealth and supercruise (prolonged supersonic cruise) capability, low-probability of intercept radar (LPIR) and advanced avionics with data fusion.

"The way our adversaries are ramping up their air power, India has to put all its efforts on full throttle before it's too late. A national task force is the need of the hour"



-AIR MARSHAL ANIL CHOPRA (RETD), *Former Director-General, Centre for Air Power Studies*

With no immediate relief in sight, IAF chief Air Chief Marshal Amar Preet Singh stated in October that the force is left with no option but to "fight with whatever we have". Simultaneously, the IAF headquarters have prepared a plan for optimisation of available resources—instead of having separate air assets dedicated for sectors facing Pakistan and China, they would be deployed in a manner where they can cover both directions. A serving air marshal tells INDIA TODAY that the plan is to keep the main fighter squadrons in western command bases like Ambala, Chandigarh, or even at Awantipur in Jammu and Kashmir so they can cover both fronts simultaneously. "Till the time we build up numbers, we have worked out a plan to deploy them at places where they can be moved to the west as well as the eastern sector. We cannot afford to have dedicated squadrons for each sector," he explains.

While the roots of the IAF's depleting numbers lie in decades of delays and a sluggish acquisition process, the tardy AMCA and other indigenous projects are due to late delivery of aircraft engines and a disconnect between the research and design (R&D) and production processes. The shortfall has compelled the IAF to still rely on old platforms like the MiG-21, which is being phased out in the coming months. Four squadrons of Jaguars will also start retiring in 2027.